coursera | MoMA

Seeing Through Photographs

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Module 4
One and Another

Part I: Introduction
Introduction to Module 4 — Reading • 2 min
Sarah Meister on Photography and Multiplicity — Video • 2 min

Part II: Albums and Books
Artwork Spotlight: Frances Benjamin Johnston's The Hampton Album, 1899–1900 — Reading • 2 min
Hear More: Sarah Meister on Frances Benjamin Johnston. The Hampton Album. 1899–1900 — Video • 1 min
Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
Photo Books — Reading • 8 min

Part III: Bodies of Work
Photo Series — Reading • 13 min
Hear More: Nicholas Nixon on The Brown Sisters, 1975–2022 — Video • 1 min
Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
Hear More: Sohrab Hura on Snow, 2015–ongoing — Video • 5 min

Part IV: One from Many
One from Many — Reading • 8 min
Hear More: Irina Rozovsky on Miracle Center, 2019–ongoing — Video • 5 min

Part V: Review and Respond
Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • Grade: 80%
Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min
Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min
Optional Mid-Course Survey — Reading • 5 min

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Part I: Introduction
Introduction to Module 5 — Reading • 2 min
Artwork Spotlight: Hank Willis Thomas's UNBRANDED series — Reading • 2 min
Hank Willis Thomas on the Role of Advertising Images — Video • 3 min

Part II: Re-envisioning History
Constructing History — Reading • 4 min
Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
Challenging History — Reading • 6 min
Hear More: Carrie Mae Weems on From Here I Saw What Happened and I Cried, 1995–96 — Video • 2 min
Hear More: Walid Raad of The Atlas Group on My neck is thinner than a hair: Engines, 1996–2001 — Video • 1 min
Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
Hear More: Harrell Fletcher on The American War, 2005 — Video • 4 min

Part III: Envisioning Selves and Stereotypes
Constructing Personal Narratives — Reading • 10 min
Hear More: Iñaki Bonillas on Constructing Identities — Video • 5 min
Hear More: Eva Respini on Cindy Sherman. Untitled Film Stills. 1977–80 — Video • 1 min
Hear More: David Alekhuogie on To Live and Die in LA, 2019 — Video • 4 min

Part IV: Review and Respond
Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • 30 min
Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min
Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min

Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

Constructing Personal Narratives

0:00 / 9:38 1x

Blanche Parker



Blanche Parker. *The Story of my life and friends as told by snapshots from fourteen on.* 1916–23. Album of 680 gelatin silver prints, overall 10 × 13" (25.4 × 33 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Peter J. Cohen

Photography has the power to illuminate personal narratives, and many people sequence photographs in albums or scrapbooks to recollect events and places they hold dear. This page is from one of two photo albums assembled by Blanche Parker and captures, as she put it, her "life and friends, as told by snapshots, from fourteen on." The albums track her travels around the United States and Canada and her career at telephone companies as one of the era's "weavers of speech" responsible for connecting callers. Photography enabled Parker to chronicle her life, and more broadly, amateur photography and photo albums have become an essential and rich part of the medium's history.

Cindy Sherman



Cindy Sherman. *Untitled Film Still #13.* 1978. Gelatin silver print, 9 7/16 x 7 1/2" (24 x 19.1 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Jo Carole and Ronald S. Lauder in memory of Eugene M. Schwartz. © 2020 Cindy Sherman



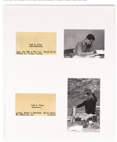
Cindy Sherman. *Untitled Film Still #14.* 1978. Gelatin silver print, 9 7/16 x 7 1/2" (24 x 19.1 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Jo Carole and Ronald S. Lauder in memory of Eugene M. Schwartz. © 2020 Cindy Sherman

Cindy Sherman's Untitled Film Stills is a suite of seventy black-and-white photographs in which the artist posed in the guises of various generic female film characters, among them, ingénue, working girl, vamp, and lonely housewife. Staged to resemble scenes from Classic Hollywood, film noir, B movies, and European art-house films, the printed images mimic in format, scale, and quality the often-staged "stills" used to promote films. By photographing herself in such roles, Sherman inserts herself into a dialogue about stereotypical portrayals of women. Whether she was the one to release the camera's shutter or not, she is considered the author of the photographs. However, the works in Untitled Film Stills are not considered self-portraits.

Iñaki Bonillas



Iñaki Bonillas. *A Card for J.R. Plaza.* 2007. Six pigmented inkjet prints, each 10 1/16 × 8 1/16" (25.6 × 20.5 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Latin American and Caribbean Fund. © 2020 Iñaki Bonillas



Detail from Iñaki Bonillas. *A Card for J.R. Plaza.* 2007.

To create this work, Iñaki Bonillas pored over photographs, albums, and slides he inherited from his grandfather, J. R. Plaza. Included in the archive was a sheet of business cards, each corresponding to a position Plaza held during his professional life as a salesman. Intermixed among these were eleven cards Plaza designed and typed, representing professions he never held, including borreguero (shepherd) and modelo (model). Inspired by the cards, Bonillas paired several of his grandfather's self-portraits with the fictitious business cards, playfully exploring Plaza's interest in self-presentation and constructing a series of new narratives about his own family history. Bonillas also inherited Plaza's typewriter, which inspired him to create one last business card: "self-portraitist."

Wolfgang Tillmans



Wolfgang Tillmans. *MoMA installation (1986–1998).* 2012. Twenty-nine chromogenic color prints, one pigmented inkjet print, installation: 148 × 483" (375.9 × 1226.8 cm). Installation view, *Contemporary Galleries: 1980–Now*, The Museum of Modern Art, New York, November 16, 2011–February 09, 2014. Photo: Thomas Griesel. © 2020 Wolfgang Tillmans



Detail from Wolfgang Tillmans. *MoMA installation (1986–1998).* 2012.

Wolfgang Tillmans mines his archives of photographs to construct constellations of images combined specifically for the space of each of his exhibitions. This installation presents staged and candid photographs of his friends and scenes from his own life—images that also function individually—printed at various scales and in both black-and-white and color. He perceives this very personal aesthetic investigation to have distinct political resonance, explaining: "Growing up in the '80s, questions of style and music and youth culture all seemed inherently political. . . . So in that way, I was so excited about the connection between our private lives and politics."

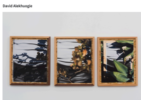
Song Dong



Song Dong. *Breathing.* 1996. Two color transparencies (diptych), two light boxes, printed 2018, each 61 1/2 × 91" (156.2 × 231.1 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Carl Jacobs Fund. © 2020 Song Dong

Song Dong abruptly stopped making art in 1989, after China's violent military response to the Tiananmen Square protests. Though he trained as a painter, when he resumed making art a few years later he turned to performance, photography, and video. On New Year's Eve the artist laid face down on the ground of Tiananmen Square in subzero conditions, remaining for forty minutes, until the condensation from his breath formed a thin layer of ice. When he repeated the act on the frozen surface of Houhai, a lake in Beijing, the heat of his breath had no effect. Recalling the outcome of the Tiananmen Square protests, this performance called attention to the efforts of individuals in challenging monolithic powers and the extreme difficulty of affecting change. Song's performance represents his direct engagement with history, and was documented by his wife and collaborator, Yin Xiuzen and made into large-scale photographic transparencies backed by light boxes.

David Alekhuogie



David Alekhuogie. Left: *rancho cucamonga 34.1664° N, 117.5931° W.* 2018. Middle: *echo park 34.0782°N, 118.2606° W.* 2018. Right: *compton cvs 33.8958° N, 118.2201° W.* 2018. All pigmented inkjet prints on canvas, artist's frames, 22 x 17 3/4" (55.9 x 45.1 cm). Installation view, *to live & die in LA*, Commonwealth and Council, Los Angeles, January 19–March 2, 2019. Photo: Rueben Diaz. Courtesy the artist and Commonwealth and Council, Los Angeles. © 2020 David Alekhuogie

David Alekhuogie gives his photography students an assignment: Travel around your community, and document the parts of the landscape you feel you're impacting and are impacted by. To gain perspective, he completed the assignment himself, bringing multiple photographic prints of a closely cropped Black male body out onto the Los Angeles city streets and re-photographing them in significant locations. Some were photographed at sites related to the city's history, others at sites of personal traumatic memories. The resulting works not only identify places across the city that have shaped his own identity, but also map the artist's relationship to this place. By inserting his photographs into the landscape, Alekhuogie sees himself as augmenting rather than rewriting history.

Dionne Lee



Dionne Lee. *North.* 2019. Gelatin silver print (collage), graphite, 14 x 11" (35.6 x 27.9 cm). Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2026 Dionne Lee

In Dionne Lee's work, the landscape is a refuge as well as a site of trauma. As a child growing up in Harlem, Lee often spent time in Central Park. This memory was reframed later in life when Lee conducted research on the history of Seneca Village, a 19th century settlement founded by free Blacks, who were forcibly removed from the land in order to erect the park that would later provide Lee's first experience with the "natural world." Now, making and teaching photography in Northern California, she interrogates the history of American landscape photography, asking questions about who captured these images, and for what purposes.

Lee's images are, in part, shaped by a desire to reconstruct and reclaim personal history. *North* shows her hands outstretched toward the sky as she performs a survival skill intended to help locate the North Star. Lee states that by embodying this action she imagines the "people who were fleeing the South during enslavement" potentially her "ancestors could have held their body in that same position" to navigate their way north.

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